

3 LEVELS OF HAPPY BIRTHDAY

From Simple to Pro



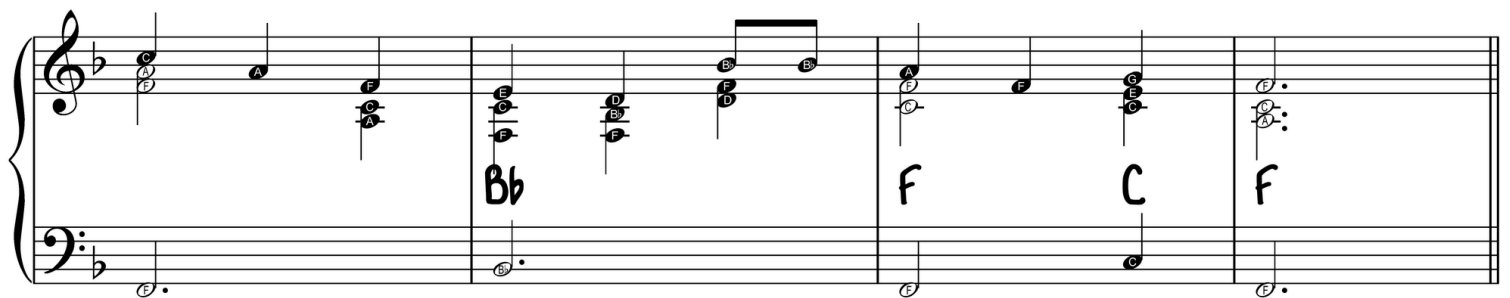
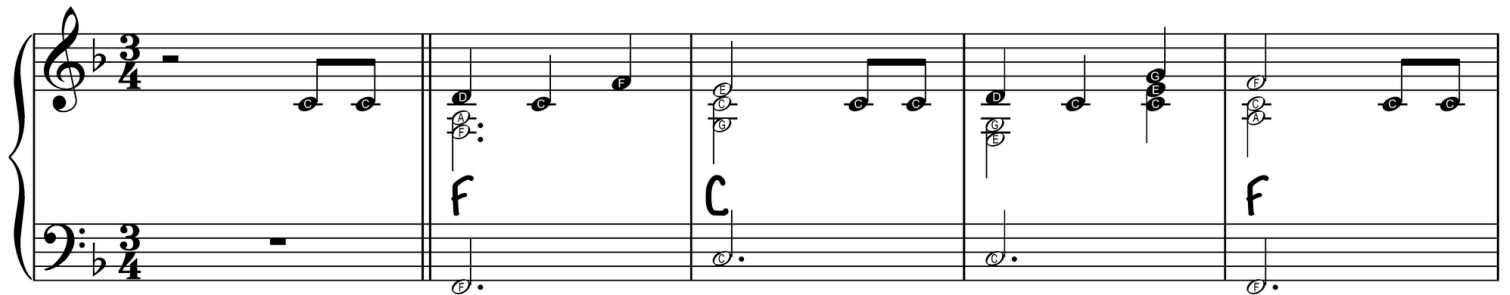
Introduction from Adam

Happy Birthday is the one song every pianist ends up playing. In this lesson, we'll build it up through three levels — from a simple version to a smooth, classy arrangement and finally a spicy pro reharmon.

Level #1

Vanilla Version video 1:04

We start with the original harmony, using only the three **primary chords** in the key: I, IV, and V. This gives us the classic, familiar version of Happy Birthday.



Keeping things simple like this builds a solid foundation, making it much easier to understand and appreciate the reharmonisations that follow.

Level #2

Smooth & Classy



video 2:30

Now we start adding a little more colour. Instead of jumping straight between the main chords, we introduce inversions and passing chords to help the harmony flow more smoothly.

Small tweaks make a big difference here. We add stepping-stone chords like an inversion between F + C and explore the **relative minor** (Dm7) instead of resolving straight home.

We also slipped in a **gospel-style diminished** passing chord to create movement. Later, a **IV minor colour** (B $\flat$ m) adds a beautiful touch of tension before resolving.



"To finish, we use a gospel-style walkdown that adds movement before the final resolution!"

Level #3

Super Spicy



video 6:58

Now we turn the creativity all the way up. This pro reharm adds more colour, more movement, and a few richer jazz and gospel ideas.

We introduce extra **walk-ups** and **stepping-stone chords** to connect the harmony, creating a stronger sense of forward motion. You'll also hear a "rock" between the I and IV chords, a classic gospel move that adds energy and groove.

The musical score is presented in two systems. The first system is in 3/4 time and features a piano part with chords F, Gm11, F/A, C, C7, Dm7, C7/E, and F. A red arrow points to the C7 chord with the annotation "Rock!". The second system is in 4/4 time and features a piano part with chords Cm7, F7, C/Bb, Bb, Gb, Dm7, Db7, C7b9, and F. Chords Cm7, F7, and Gb are highlighted with red dashed boxes.

Later, we use a **ii-V-I** into the IV chord, a **half-diminished** colour, and some punchy stabs to bring extra drama and tension.

The result is a much bigger, more expressive version that transforms a simple tune into a full, professional-sounding arrangement!